

ADA / WCAG 2.1 Accessibility Audit

Colorado Judicial Branch — Homepage

Page	Colorado Judicial Branch — Homepage
URL	https://www.coloradojudicial.gov/
Standard	Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.1, Level AA
Audit Date	May 5, 2026
Method	Code- and structure-level review of public HTML; not a substitute for automated scanning, screen-reader testing, or live keyboard testing.

Summary

The Colorado Judicial Branch homepage demonstrates many positive accessibility practices, including a present skip link, declared page language, descriptive page title, alternative text on all images, properly labeled social-media links, structured landmarks, an ARIA-compliant tab widget, defined focus styles, and live regions for dynamic content. Twelve issues are identified. One is critical: a CMS developer artifact heading present in the DOM. Four are high severity, including duplicate element ids, inactive tab panels not hidden from assistive technology, a mobile navigation toggle implemented as an `<input type="checkbox">` rather than a button, and a banner link with no accessible name. The remaining seven are medium and low severity and can be addressed during routine maintenance.

What the Page Does Well

Skip navigation link. “Skip to main content” is present (WCAG 2.4.1).
Page language. <code>lang="en"</code> is declared on the <code><html></code> element (WCAG 3.1.1).
Descriptive page title. “Home Colorado Judicial Branch” (WCAG 2.4.2).
Image alt text. All images have an <code>alt</code> attribute (WCAG 1.1.1).
Social-media icon links. All have <code>aria-label</code> and <code>title</code> attributes (WCAG 2.4.6).
Landmarks. <code><main></code> , <code><header></code> , and <code><footer></code> landmarks are present (WCAG 1.3.6).
Tab widget. Uses <code>role="tab"</code> , <code>aria-selected</code> , <code>aria-controls</code> , and matching <code>tabpanel</code> ids (WCAG 4.1.2). See Issue 3 below for an inactive-panel concern.
Focus styles. Defined in the stylesheet (WCAG 2.4.7).
H1 heading. Present and descriptive (WCAG 1.3.1).

Live regions. aria-live regions are present for dynamic content (WCAG 4.1.3).

Issues Found

Critical

1. Exposed Internal / Developer Heading in the DOM

WCAG 1.3.1, 2.4.6 (Level A / AA) · Fail

An `<h2>General Content Search API Homepage</h2>` appears in the document outline, hidden via `display: none`. This appears to be a CMS or developer artifact that was never intended for public display. While it is currently hidden with CSS, it is still read by some screen readers and appears in the DOM's heading outline. Screen-reader users navigating by headings will encounter a confusing, out-of-place heading between the H1 and the actual page-content headings.

Fix. Remove this heading from the template entirely, or ensure it is properly programmatically hidden with `aria-hidden="true"` if it must remain.

High Priority

2. Duplicate Element IDs

WCAG 4.1.1 (Parsing, Level A) · Fail

Two sets of ids are duplicated in the DOM: `views-exposed-form-general-content-search-api-block-general-content-search-api-mini` appears twice, and `courtlocator` appears twice. Duplicate ids break ARIA relationships such as `aria-labelledby` and `for` attributes on labels. Assistive technologies use ids to find labels and associated controls; when duplicated, behavior is undefined and frequently broken.

Fix. Each id must be unique per page. The duplicate search forms (desktop and mobile) should use distinct ids with the same ARIA label text applied independently.

3. Inactive Tab Panels Not Hidden from Assistive Technology

WCAG 4.1.2 (Name, Role, Value, Level A) · Fail

All four tab panels (`tabpanel-1` through `tabpanel-4`) have `display: block`, and none have `aria-hidden="true"` applied to inactive panels. Screen-reader users will encounter all four courts' content as if it is always open, rather than experiencing the tab interface as intended.

Fix. Apply `aria-hidden="true"` and / or the `hidden` attribute to inactive tab panels and remove these when a tab is activated. The active panel should have `aria-hidden="false"` or no `aria-hidden` attribute at all.

4. Mobile Navigation Toggle Uses `<input type="checkbox">` Without ARIA

WCAG 4.1.2 (Name, Role, Value, Level A) · Fail

The hamburger / mobile-nav toggle is implemented as `<input type="checkbox" id="navbar__toggle--state">` — a CSS-only pattern. It lacks `role="button"` (or conversion to a proper `<button>` element), `aria-expanded` (which should toggle between `true` and `false`), and `aria-controls` pointing to the navigation element. Keyboard-only and screen-reader users cannot reliably operate a checkbox as a navigation toggle.

Fix. Replace with a `<button>` element that toggles `aria-expanded="true|false"` and includes `aria-controls` pointing to the navigation menu's id.

5. Anniversary Banner Link Has No Accessible Name

WCAG 2.4.4 (Link Purpose in Context, Level A) · Fail

The 150th Anniversary banner image is wrapped in a link `<a href="/node/16553">`, but the link's accessible name resolves to just "Image" (from a child `<div>`). The image inside has `alt="Decorative -- Colorado Courts 150th Anniversary Logo banner"`, but the word "Decorative" signals the alt should be empty. This creates a conflict: if the image is decorative, the link has no accessible name; if it is informative, the word "Decorative" is misleading.

Fix. Either give the link an explicit `aria-label` describing its destination (for example, "Learn about Colorado Courts' 150th Anniversary"), or make the image alt text the link's accessible name by removing "Decorative --" from the alt text. Remove the visible text "Image" from the DOM, or hide it with `aria-hidden="true"`.

Medium Priority

6. Multiple Navigation Landmarks Share the Same Name

WCAG 1.3.6 (Identify Purpose) / best practice · Fail

Two `<nav>` elements are both labeled "Secondary navigation" — one for desktop and one for mobile. While each is a separate region, having two landmarks with identical names is confusing for screen-reader users who navigate by landmarks, since they will encounter two indistinguishable "Secondary navigation" regions.

Fix. Distinguish them with unique labels — for example, `aria-label="Secondary navigation (desktop)"` and `aria-label="Secondary navigation (mobile)"` — or hide the inactive one with `aria-hidden="true"` when it is not in use.

7. Search Forms Lack `role="search"`

WCAG 1.3.6 (Identify Purpose, Level AAA / best practice at AA) · Fail

Three search-form instances appear on the page. None have `role="search"` applied. This landmark role allows screen-reader users to jump directly to site search functionality.

Fix. Add `role="search"` to each `<form>` used for site search, or wrap each in a `<div role="search">`.

8. Court Locator Form Has No Submit Button or JavaScript-Free Fallback

WCAG 2.1.1 (Keyboard), 4.1.2 (Name, Role, Value), Level A · Fail

The #courtlocator form contains no visible inputs or submit button in the static HTML; it appears to rely entirely on JavaScript to populate. Users without JavaScript, or users on assistive technology whose JavaScript interactions differ, may encounter a non-functional form with no fallback.

Fix. Ensure the form is functional without JavaScript, or display a fallback message. At minimum, include a visible submit button rendered in the initial HTML.

9. Search Inputs Missing autocomplete Attribute

WCAG 1.3.5 (Identify Input Purpose, Level AA) · Fail

All three search text inputs are missing the autocomplete attribute. While search fields are somewhat exempt, adding autocomplete="off" or a relevant token explicitly communicates intent.

Fix. Add autocomplete="off" to all site-search fields to clearly signal intent and meet 1.3.5.

10. Heading Hierarchy Has a Gap

WCAG 1.3.1 (Info and Relationships, Level A) · Fail

The heading structure jumps from multiple <h2> elements directly to an <h3> (“Helpful Resources”) with no <h2> parent grouping that section contextually. The hierarchy is: H1 (Welcome to the Colorado Courts and Probation) → H2 (Docket Search) → H2 (Self Help and Forms by Topic) → H2 (Find your courts) → **H3 (Helpful Resources)** → H2 (Colorado’s Courts) → H2 (Our Mission). The H3 sits between two H2s with no parent-child relationship.

Fix. Change “Helpful Resources” to <h2> to maintain a consistent outline, or restructure the section so the H3 is logically subordinate to a preceding H2.

Low Priority / Best Practice

11. Image Alt Texts Are Generic for Informative Images

WCAG 1.1.1 (Non-text Content, Level A) · Fail

Several images have alt text that may not be sufficiently descriptive for informative use: alt="Money Cases" (photo used for “Pay a Fine”), alt="e-filing" (photo used for “Webex Virtual Courtrooms” — the alt does not match the context), and alt="Mission" (generic).

Fix. Ensure alt text describes the image’s content *and* its purpose in context. The e-filing image used in the Webex section, for example, should have alt text reflecting virtual courtrooms rather than e-filing.

12. External Links Do Not Consistently Warn of New Window

WCAG 3.2.2 (On Input) / best practice · Fail

Several external links (e.g. “Online Payments,” “Workplace Culture Initiative”) open in new tabs or windows. While these links contain “(Link is external)” text injected by a , no link includes an “opens in new window/tab” warning. Screen-reader users may not interpret “(Link is external)” as a new-window warning.

Fix. Add aria-label text or a visually hidden that explicitly says “opens in a new tab” for all target="_blank" links. This is distinct from indicating internal vs. external.

Priority Summary

Issues are listed in the order they are described above. Severity reflects likely barrier to a screen-reader or keyboard-only user navigating the homepage and reaching primary court services.

#	Issue	WCAG Criterion	Severity
1	Exposed CMS / developer heading in DOM	1.3.1, 2.4.6	Critical
2	Duplicate element IDs	4.1.1	High
3	Inactive tab panels not hidden from assistive tech	4.1.2	High
4	Mobile nav toggle is a checkbox, no ARIA state	4.1.2	High
5	Anniversary banner link has no accessible name	2.4.4	High
6	Two <nav> landmarks with identical names	1.3.6	Medium
7	Search forms missing role="search"	1.3.6	Medium
8	Court locator form lacks submit button / JS fallback	2.1.1, 4.1.2	Medium
9	Search inputs missing autocomplete attribute	1.3.5	Medium
10	Heading hierarchy gap (H2 → H3 → H2)	1.3.1	Medium
11	Some image alt text generic or mismatched	1.1.1	Low
12	External / new-window links do not announce new tab	3.2.2	Low

Recommended Remediation Order

1. Remove the exposed CMS / developer heading (Issue 1) and resolve the duplicate element ids (Issue 2). These are foundational issues that affect the integrity of the entire DOM and the ARIA-relationship features that depend on it.
2. Fix the inactive tab-panel exposure (Issue 3) and the mobile-nav toggle ARIA state (Issue 4). Both directly affect navigation for screen-reader and keyboard users on the homepage's most prominent interactive surfaces.
3. Resolve the anniversary-banner link accessible name (Issue 5). This is a user-facing component on the homepage that currently provides no destination context to assistive technology.
4. Address the medium-priority items (Issues 6 through 10) during the next regular content or template release. Issue 8 (court locator JavaScript fallback) is particularly worth attention because it can render the form non-operational for some users entirely.
5. Handle the low-priority items (Issues 11 and 12) as part of routine content review. Both are simple to remediate per instance.

Scope and Limitations

This audit is based on a structural review of the page's public HTML and is not a substitute for a full accessibility evaluation. A complete audit would additionally include automated testing (axe-core, WAVE, Lighthouse), manual screen-reader testing across NVDA, JAWS, and VoiceOver, keyboard-only navigation testing, color-contrast measurement on the rendered DOM at the exact rendered pixel sizes (especially for white text on the dark navy background and the "LOOKUP" label styling), and mobile and responsive-layout testing. This document does not constitute legal advice regarding compliance with the Americans with Disabilities Act, Colorado House Bill 21-1110, Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act, or any other statute or regulation. It is a technical conformance review against WCAG 2.1 Level AA criteria intended to support a remediation conversation with the operator of the page.